



CHILOE CHILE

A Fine Feast in Southern Chile

An enchanted island archipelago, Chiloé is a bewitching place of silent forests and craggy peaks that tumble down to fishing villages and mist-shrouded bays. Once believed to be a place of demonic and benevolent spirits, its fishermen still look out for a beautiful mermaid, La Pincoya, who is said to ensure a bountiful catch – and fresh ingredients for *curanto*, an ancient feast.



Separated from mainland Chile by the narrow Chacao Channel, the Chiloé archipelago comprises one large island, Isla Grande, and several smaller ones. A magical, mystical world of emerald woods and silent fjords, its indigenous people, the Mapuche, lived here undiscovered for millennia until Spanish conquistadors arrived in the 1500s. Spain steered Chiloé on a historical course quite distinct from the mainland: the archipelago evolved its own culture, a unique cuisine, and a distinctive mythology rooted in Spanish Catholicism and Mapuche legend, with mythological figures like La Pincoya. In the 1600s, Jesuit missionaries built wooden churches across Chiloé to evangelize the Mapuche, and colorful towns grew around them.

On Isla Grande, Chiloé's capital city, Castro, is the archipelago's cultural heart. A small city of hilly lanes and fishermen's houses built on wooden stilts on the waters of the Castro Fjord, it was the beachhead for attempts to conquer the Mapuche. Nowadays, it is a springboard for inspirational road and ferry trips that travel through haunting waters, forest-cloaked mountains, and spooky fishermen's villages full of ghostly churches and tales of witchcraft.

Traditional customs still abound, and the steamy feast known as *curanto* seems to have sprung from the old fishermen's habit of adding fresh fish to long-life foods such as cured meats, which they kept on board in case the weather forced them to stay at sea for weeks at a time. *Curanto* still blends shellfish and fish with meats such as pork and chicken in a kind of ancient "clambake" that's unique to this southern archipelago.

Traditionally, islanders cook *curanto* by digging a wide pit in the ground in which they build a fire beneath smooth, round stones. Once these are hot, the flames are doused, and a blanketing layer of the huge native *nalca* leaves is spread over the stones. Layers of food are then piled on – fresh seafood, including baby mussels, clams, and fish, then meat and vegetables, including pork, chicken, potatoes, dumpling-like *chapaleles*, and *milacos*, a mix of fried raw potatoes, butter, and crackling. The food is covered with more *nalca* leaves, and then stones or chunks of sod to trap the heat, and the food is left to cook slowly over several hours. Today, restaurants prepare *curanto* "a la olla" – in huge cauldron-like pots, from which they serve small mountains of its many meats and vegetables. It's a magical concoction that's strangely perfect in these mystical islands.

Three Days on Chiloé

Frequent bus and ferry services connect the islands in the archipelago, but you'll need to rent a car to really explore the back-country roads and village life.

DAY ONE Visit **Castro**, Chiloé's capital. Tour **Iglesia San Francisco**, a UNESCO-protected Jesuit church; then descend hilly lanes to the **Castro Fjord**. Stroll along the waterfront, past the stilted, wooden fishermen's homes in the water. Go to the **Museo de Arte Moderno Chiloé**, where modern art examines Chiloé's island identity.

DAY TWO Rent a car and explore **Isla Grande**. Head north to **Ancud**, a historic fort settlement; then drive south to **Chonchi**, a village built into a vertiginous cliff overlooking a scenic bay. Visit **Iglesia de Chonchi**, a Jesuit church whose vanilla-and-powder-blue facade hides a vaulted interior painted with a thousand tiny white stars.

DAY THREE Hop on a ferry to small **Isla de Quinchao**, to walk the beaches and the gravel streets of old fishing village **Curaco de Vélez**. Back in **Castro**, round out your stay with a visit to a waterside restaurant for a dinner of steamy *curanto*.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Fly to Santiago international airport, then take a domestic flight to the southern mainland city, Puerto Montt, where ferries cross to Chiloé.

WHERE TO STAY

Hotel Huildin (inexpensive) has garden cabins and rooms in Chonchi. www.hotelhuildin.cl

Hotel Unicornio Azul (moderate) is a restored 1910 building set on the Castro waterfront. www.hotelgaleonazul.cl

Hostería Ancud (expensive) overlooks the ocean and Ancud's historic fort. +56 65 622 340

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.visit-chile.org

